Your magazine from Gallions

Gallions Housing Association

thamesview

news • events • competitions



GALLIONS' RESIDENTS CREATE A HIDDEN TREASURE 5-6

SOUTHMERE VILLAGE UPDATE 18

VOLUNTEER CANAL CLEAN UP 12-13

PEABODY ROADSHOW 26

August 2013 • www.gallionsha.co.uk

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Get in touch

Contact us: 0300 123 1237

Write to us: PO BOX 268, Sidcup, DA15 0FB

Visit us: 15 Joyce Dawson Way, London, SE28 8RA

Open between 9am and 5pm on Monday, Tuesday, Thursday and Friday. On Wednesdays we are open from 9am until 6pm.

Or telephone us.

Customer Contact Team: 0300 123 1237

Repairs Contact Team: 0300 123 1238

Gas appliances servicing and break downs: 020 8300 0300

Text Relay: 18001

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RESIDENT ADVICE

This section explains what advice Gallions, our partners and local community groups would like to tell residents. This could include ways you can get involved with your local community or advice on money, housing or DIY activities.

NEIGHBOURS

This section explains what's going on in your neighbourhood - everything from events to what exciting projects your neighbours are up to and ways to get involved.

If you would like to submit an article to this section please email communications@gallionsha.co.uk or call 0208 308 4080

TENANTS VIEW

This section is for residents by residents. Get involved and write an article from your point of view on what's happening in your community. Get your neighbours talking about local issues or things to celebrate!

If you would like to submit an article to this section please email communications@gallionsha.co.uk or call 0208 308 4080

GALLIONS

This section is where you be able to find the latest information on what Gallions is up to; everything from performance to what local offers we have available. You will find out all the latest information from your landlord here.

EVENTS

This section is where you can sit back with a cup of tea or coffee and plan your events & have a go at our cross-words and win some prizes.

WELCOME

We hope you have been enjoying your summer so far and have been able to take part in some of the great activities that Gallions and our partners have hosted! You can read more about our neighbourhoods event that we hosted on 16 July on page 26 and make sure you check out the canal clean up story on page 12 and 13.

This month we featured local residents' treasure - their garden, which is located in Titmuss Avenue. These residents have worked very hard to get the garden looking in top shape for summer and continue to work on it almost every day! Check out the photos of page 5 and 6.

To see photos of the demolition taking place in Southmere Village check them out on page 18 - this is a huge milestone in the project and residents are happy to see the project accelerating forward.



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Resident Editors
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Gallions Residents Group

Gallions Housing Association

GALLIONS' RESIDENTS CREATE A HIDDEN TREASURE

RESIDENTS INVOLVED WITH 'FRIENDS OF THAMESMEAD PARKS GROUP' HAVE CREATED THEIR OWN HIDDEN TREASURE RIGHT IN THE CENTRE OF THAMESMEAD.

The garden, located near Gallions' old office along Titmuss Avenue, has taken shape in the last few months and the seeds they planted last autumn are growing into beautiful flowers and yummy vegetables and fruit.

One of the youngest residents involved, eleven year old Mercedes Crow, wrote a story about her experience as one of the gardeners and wanted to share it with fellow Thamesview readers...

The Community Garden

Community gardens are not just about growing stuff, it's about meeting new people and learning new things. You can learn new things every day. Some plants are harder than others to grow.

The garden in Titmuss Avenue is a great success. There are thirteen raised beds for thirteen different families to use and children have been given old car tyres filled with soil to plant their own seeds.

Most of the building materials used in the garden are recycled. For instance, an old plastic dog bed has been made into a little pond surrounded by big stones, covered in soil and planted with marsh land plants. This already has water insects living in it. →



The community garden below

Among the plants already growing, are apple, pear, plum, cherry and greengage trees. There are also raspberry, blackberry, blackcurrant and redcurrant bushes as well as rhubarb and strawberry plants.

Among the vegetables being grown are, runner beans, broad beans, peas, carrots, cabbage, brussel sprouts, garlic, onions, potatoes, tomatoes, beetroot, swede, parsnips etc.

We have put up bird feeders, bird nest box and an insect hotel. We built a poly tunnel where we start our seeds off and we have an old sea container, which we use as our shed, where we keep our tools.

In the garden, the wildlife we have seen so far, are birds, butterflies, ladybirds, bees and a family of foxes. The people who are involved (including myself) are very happy to have the privilege to be part of this project.

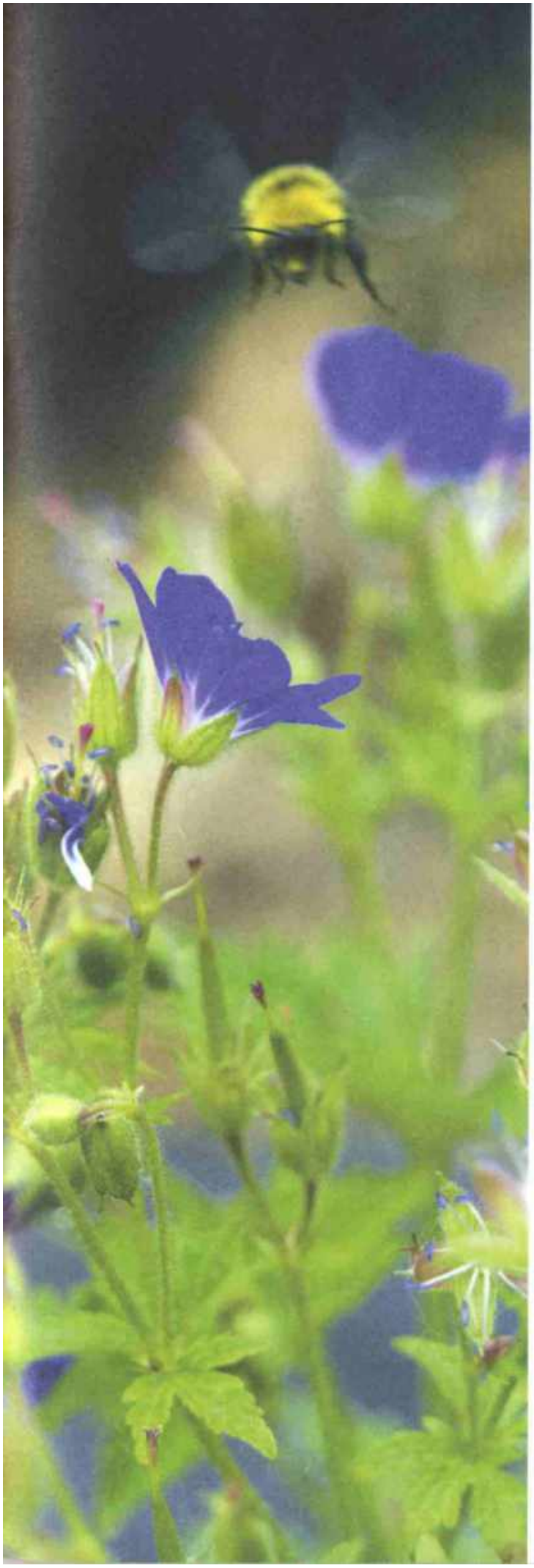
By Mercedes Crow, age 11

To find out more about the garden and how you can get involved contact: Kelly Sullivan Community Engagement Officer t:020 8308 4134 e:ksullivan@gallionsha.co.uk





Residents who have green thumbs!



GREAT OPPORTUNITY TO LEARN NEW SKILLS!



If you live in Thamesmead, are aged over 16, unemployed and would like to take advantage of free training courses, why not sign-up with Trust Thamesmead's job search and training department (Building Futures). They will assess you, based on your own individual needs, to see what's right for you.

Current courses being advertised include employability skills, every day I.T. and apprenticeships in construction. Spaces are subject to meeting certain requirements and availability.

Telephone Sharon Hawe on 020 8320 4472 for more information.

FAIR MONEY ADVICE FROM FAIR FINANCE

FAIR FINANCE OFFERS FREE IMPARTIAL AND CONFIDENTIAL ADVICE TO ANYBODY THAT NEEDS HELP MANAGING THEIR MONEY. THEY ALSO OFFER AFFORDABLE LOANS TO HELP WITH ANYTHING FROM SCHOOL UNIFORMS TO DEBT CONSOLIDATION AND MICROCREDIT LOANS FOR NEW AND EXISTING BUSINESSES.

If you need advice on your finances or if you're in debt, Fair Finance can help you sort out your finances with programmes they offer, such as 'Fair Money Advice'. This programme has been providing free advice since 2001, and has helped over 5,000 customers deal with £24 million of combined rental and consumer debts, and has served over 5,000 people in debt.



The service offers a free, confidential and impartial appointment. If you have concerns regarding debt, rent or mortgage arrears or are experiencing financial difficulty, then why not book an appointment with an advisor?

Their other programme, 'Fair Personal Loans' offer a cheaper alternative to door step lenders and loan sharks. This is a personalised service and considers each individual case in their own circumstance; decisions are not solely based on a credit rating or a computer saying 'no'.



Trust Thamesmead, who have been in partnership with Fair Finance, are thrilled that this kind of helpful and trusting money advice is offered to residents of Thamesmead.

Trust Thamesmead's Chief Executive, Mick Hayes said: "Fair Finance are making a significant impact on the lives of some of the most financially-excluded people in Thamesmead by providing debt advice, financial

capability workshops and affordable loans.

Over three years (2012-15), they aim to make an estimated £1m saving on interest payments. Local residents, in particular those who are already financially excluded, will be supported to get on their feet and to feel more in control of their financial situation. Financial capability workshops will support some of the poorest residents to make smarter and more informed choices".

What their clients are saying:

"The service was very helpful. I did not know where to turn to, but Fair Money Advice took the time to explain things clearly and I received a plan of how to move forward. I first received advice over the telephone where the advisor asked me questions and offered solutions – this reassured me and gave me the confidence to attend an appointment."

"The service was excellent. We needed the money in a hurry and received it within one week. We had payday loans which were expensive – Fair Personal Loans were much more flexible and affordable."

IF YOU NEED FINANCIAL HELP PLEASE GET IN CONTACT WITH FAIR FINANCE:

Fair Finance are based at Trust Thamesmead's office in Thamesmead Town Centre 9:00am-5:00pm every Tuesday, Wednesday and Friday.

Appointments must be booked in advance by
t: 020 8320 4470 or 0208 988 0627
or e: info@fairmoneyadvice.co.uk



Fair Finance staff

GALLIONS' VULNERABILITY POLICY

OUR NEW POLICY PROVIDES INFORMATION ON DIFFERENT TYPES OF VULNERABILITY AND THE SERVICES WE PROVIDE TO ASSIST VULNERABLE RESIDENTS. THE POLICY INCLUDES HOW STAFF MAKE ASSESSMENTS, AND WHAT ACTION AND SUPPORT IS OFFERED AFTERWARDS.

The policy also provides information on what different teams within the organisation can provide, including:

- asset management's enhanced repairs service
- the revenue team's approach if vulnerable residents fall into arrears
- all staff communications, including correspondence in other languages, and;
- liaison with external agencies who can provide support

Here are some of the services we offer vulnerable residents:

- Very frail elderly, and residents with serious physical or learning disabilities, can have low level repairs including the provision of replacement toilet seats, bleeding radiators, installing light bulbs etc.
- Domestic Violence victims – we will carry out additional repairs around security, including if perpetrator has keys, carry out a lock change, make windows/doors secure to property, if necessary including extra front door locks.
- Very frail elderly, tenants with very young children (under 12 months) or pre-school children with respiratory problems and residents with serious health issues such as heart conditions, respiratory insufficiency, severe asthma and COPD (chronic obstructive pulmonary disease).

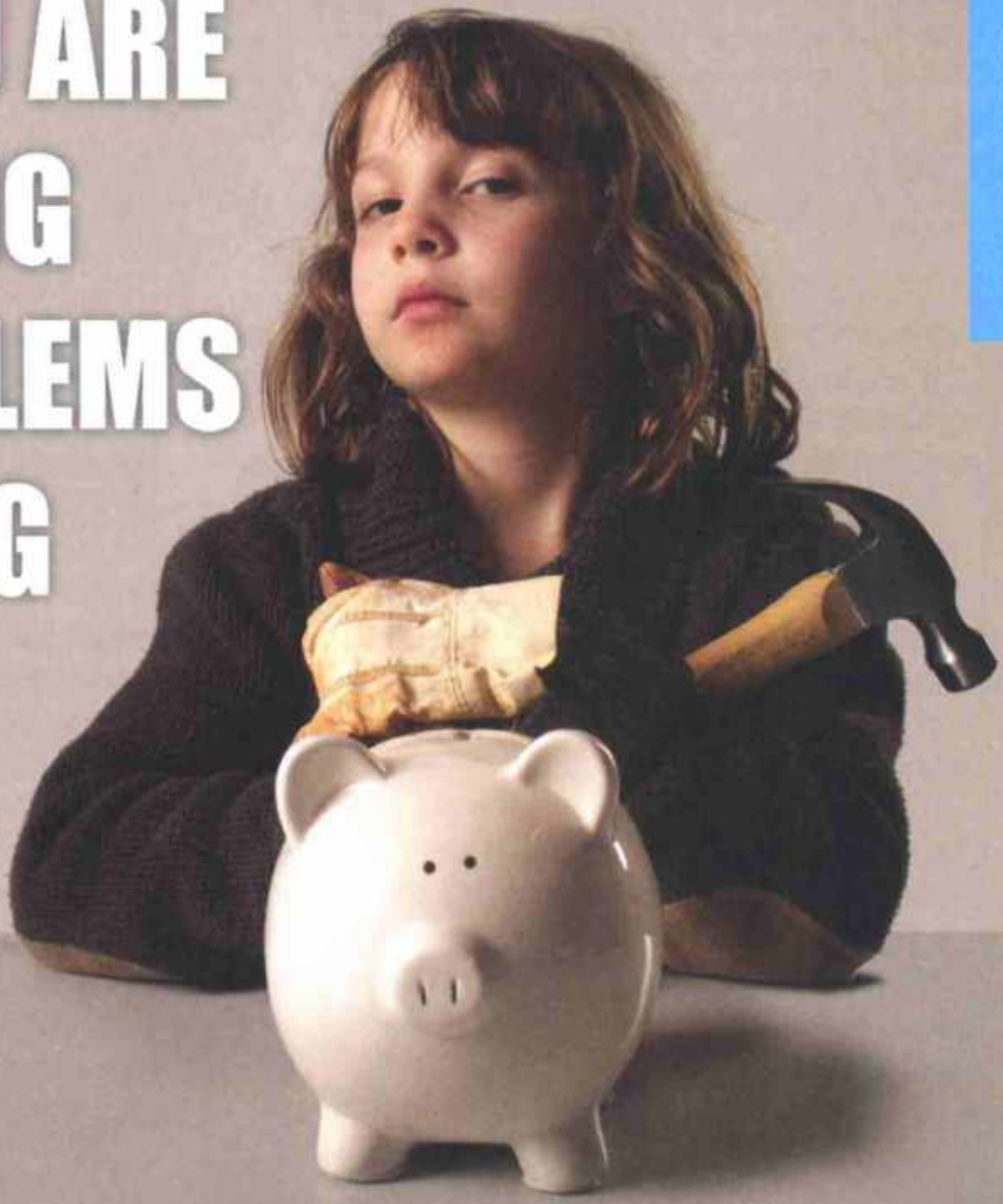
  This would warrant the arrangement of a quicker response time to complete heating and loss of hot water works. This will also apply to a request for a surveyor's visit for issues such as damp.

We aim to make sure that all our staff and contractors are aware of the policy and that we all have a responsibility to understand the importance of reporting cases where we believe residents may be vulnerable. We will also welcome information from residents if they believe there is someone in their community who may need extra support.

For more information or to let us know if you think you should be classified as vulnerable please contact:

Thelma McNamara, Housing Assistant on 0208 308 4132

IF YOU ARE HAVING PROBLEMS PAYING YOUR RENT



COME AND TALK TO US... DON'T LET IT GET THIS FAR

Contact **Gallions** on **0300 123 1237**
or visit www.gallionsha.co.uk

Our team can offer money advice, review your welfare benefits and much more.

Gallions Housing Association

VOLUNTEERS HELP SPRUCE UP LOCAL THAMESMEAD CANAL AND TOW PATH

AS PART OF THE MAYOR'S CAPITAL CLEAN-UP PROGRAMME, GALLIONS ORGANISED A BIG CLEAN UP EVENT ON WEDNESDAY 29TH MAY.

Volunteers, including Cllr Sandra Bauer, local resident, Ephraim Olumewo and our staff, got together to help spruce up Crossway Canal and tow path – an area close to Manor Close Hall in Thamesmead.

We were joined by individuals from Community Payback; the scheme where offenders undertake unpaid work on local projects as a way of giving something back to their communities. This is one of many Capital Clean-up projects they have contributed to across London since the campaign began. On what was a damp and very cold day, the group managed to clear nearly 400kg of rubbish including 15 bin bags full of general waste, old clothes and shoes.

Cllr Bauer was really pleased to be involved in the Capital Clean-up and stressed the importance of looking after the open spaces for the enjoyment of all. She said: "Thamesmead is so rich in terms of the canals and open spaces, but these areas can be blighted by litter and fly-tipping. It is so important to have these initiatives in order for everyone to be able to enjoy these spaces in the summer months".





Local resident, Ephraim Olumewo, added: "This is such a worthwhile and necessary event; it helps make the area safer for residents and it improves the natural habitat for local wildlife. By being out here today, I'm hoping to be an example to others. I would really love them to come along to other clean up events and help make their environment look beautiful again".

Solomon Small, Canal and Waterways Coordinator, (whose job is to look after the canals and waterways) was full of praise. He said: "I am constantly amazed and impressed at the dedication of volunteers who are willing to give up some of their time for good causes; and the Capital Clean-up challenge in Thamesmead was no exception".

The campaign is led by the Mayor working hand in hand with London boroughs, housing associations, community groups, businesses and the Environment Agency.

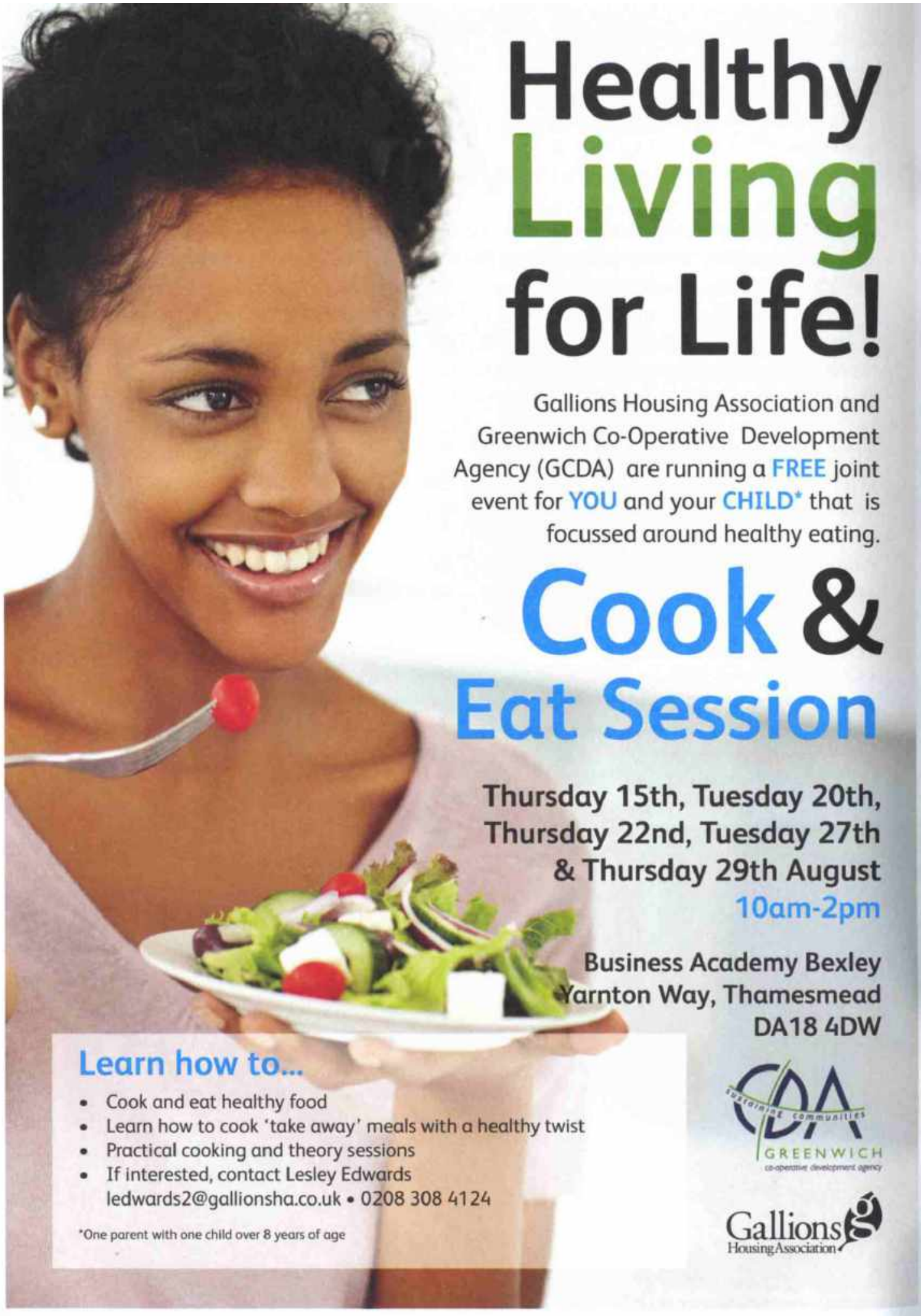
It is also part of the Mayor's Team London programme which is seeking to build a volunteering legacy following the 2012 Olympic and Paralympic Games by encouraging Londoners to do something great for their city.

The Mayor of London, Boris Johnson, said: 'Last summer Londoners showed off to the world their zeal for volunteering, helping to make this great city an even better place. I am determined to build on this community pride through my Team London programme. This spring's Capital Clean-up is a fantastic opportunity to roll up your sleeves and put something back into your local neighbourhood."

Capital Clean-up is now in its sixth year and has already championed more than 1,000 clean-up events helping London communities take part in the maintenance of the places where they live and work. In the 2011/12 campaign alone, more than 6,000 volunteers took part.







Healthy Living for Life!

Gallions Housing Association and Greenwich Co-Operative Development Agency (GCDA) are running a **FREE** joint event for **YOU** and your **CHILD*** that is focussed around healthy eating.

Cook & Eat Session

Thursday 15th, Tuesday 20th, Thursday 22nd, Tuesday 27th & Thursday 29th August
10am-2pm

Business Academy Bexley
Yarnton Way, Thamesmead
DA18 4DW

Learn how to...

- Cook and eat healthy food
- Learn how to cook 'take away' meals with a healthy twist
- Practical cooking and theory sessions
- If interested, contact Lesley Edwards ledwards2@gallionsha.co.uk • 0208 308 4124

*One parent with one child over 8 years of age

CDA sustainable communities GREENWICH co-operative development agency

Gallions Housing Association

NEIGHBOURHOOD INSPECTION DATES

Join our neighbourhood officers and wardens at a block inspection near you! If your road of block isn't listed here but you'd like to take part in an inspection let us know!
t: 0300 123 1237 e: Thamesview@gallionsha.co.uk

WATERFIELD

Neighbourhood Services Officer
Lizzy Stanley – Warden Phil Briggs

Meet at junction between Byron Close and Owen Close at 2pm

21 August 2013
9 October 2013
20 November 2013

MOORINGS

Neighbourhood Services Officer
Lizzy Stanley – Warden Phil Briggs

Meet at the junction between Titmuss Avenue and Booth Close at 2pm

16 August 2013
4 October 2013
15 November 2013

MANORWAY

Neighbourhood Services Officer
Lizzy Stanley – Warden Phil Briggs

Meet at the junction between Goldcrest Close and Whimbrel Close at 2pm

3 September 2013
3 December 2013

CROSSWAYS

Neighbourhood Services Officer
Larry Lidbury – Warden Chris Waite

Contact us if you would like to attend and we will agree a meeting place and time

3 October 2013

BROADWATERS

Neighbourhood Services Officer
Larry Lidbury – Warden Chris Waite

Meet at the junction between Whinchat Road and Wigeon Path at 2pm

28 August 2013
16 October 2013
27 November 2013

GREENMEAD

Neighbourhood Services Officer
Davinder Bal – Warden Steve Hayzen

To meet outside the post office in Lime Row at 3pm

24th October 2013 ➜

OLD CHURCH COURT- NORTHEND ROAD & BALTIMORE CLOSE

Neighbourhood Services Officer Davinder Bal – Warden Frank Smith

For Old Church Court meet by the entry gate to the car park at 2pm

For North End Road and Baltimore close telephone us if you would like to attend and we will agree a meeting place

22nd August 2013
21st November 2013

SOUTHMERE

Neighbourhood Services Officer Nathaniel Takyi-Berko
Warden Stephen Hayzen

Meet at the corner of Seacourt Road Hartslock Drive at 2pm

16th October 2013

LESNES

Neighbourhood Services Officer: Nathaniel Takyi-Berko & Neighbourhood Services Warden: Stephen Hayzen

Meet outside of Radley House (Opposite the ball court) at 2pm

17th October 2013

ST. JOSEPH'S COURT

Neighbourhood Services Officer: Nathaniel Takyi-Berko & Neighbourhood Services Warden: Frank Smith

2pm outside of 11-16 St. Joseph's Court

24th October 2013

TOWNHALL SQUARE

Neighbourhood Services Officer: Nathaniel Takyi-Berko & Neighbourhood Services Warden: Frank Smith

2pm outside of Crayford Library and Community centre

23rd October 2013

LITTLE ILFORD

Neighbourhood Services Officer Aaron Nicholson – Warden Chris Waite

Meet outside the main entrance to McLagan House at 10am

7 November 2013

BARRIER PARK

Neighbourhood Services Officer Aaron Nicholson – Warden Chris Waite

Meet outside the main entrance to Estuary House at 1pm

7 November 2013

PHOENIX WORKS – FORREST HILL

Neighbourhood Services Officer Aaron Nicholson – Warden Chris Waite
Meet outside the main entrance to Phoenix Works at 10am

15 August 2013
21 November 2013

LEWISHAM

Neighbourhood Services Officer
Aaron Nicholson – Warden Chris Waite

Meet inside the main entrance to
117 Lewisham Way at 11am

15 August 2013
21 November 2013

MILLHARBOUR

Neighbourhood Services Officer
Aaron Nicholson – Warden Chris Waite

Meet inside the main entrance to
Millharbour at 10:30am

30 August 2013
29 November 2013

CARNELL APARTMENTS

Neighbourhood Services Officer
Aaron Nicholson – Warden Chris Waite

Meet inside the main entrance to
Carnell Apartments at 12:30pm

30 August 2013
29 November 2013

GLOSTER RIDLEY COURT

Neighbourhood Services Officer
Aaron Nicholson – Warden Chris Waite

Meet in the courtyard of Gloster Ridley
Court at 1.00pm

30 August 2013
29 November 2013

LIMEHOUSE BASIN

Neighbourhood Services Officer Aaron
Nicholson – Warden Chris Waite

Meet in the courtyard of John Nash
Mews at 1:45pm

30 August 2013
29 November 2013

CARMINE WHARF

Neighbourhood Services Officer
Aaron Nicholson – Warden Chris Waite

Meet inside the main entrance to
Carmine Wharf at 2:15pm

30 August 2013
29 November 2013

SIDCUP & ORPINGTON

Neighbourhood Services Officer
Larry Lidbury

Contact us if you would like to attend
and we will agree a meeting place
and time

10 October 2013

PARKVIEW

Neighbourhood Services Officer
Davinder Bal – Warden Frank Smith

To meet outside Jacob House
at 1.30pm

24th October 2013

SOUTHMERE VILLAGE **UPDATE**

Demolition:
Demolition has started! You may have heard the works going on. The north towers (on Yarton way) have started to come down.

Demolition plan:
The demolition will take place over several stages; the first being Binsey Walk (the block roughly between the Library and the Multi Use Games Area), followed by the Tavy Bridge block, then onto the southern half of Binsey Walk.

Parking:
A reminder - there is limited parking at the Health Centre due to the relocation of hoarding. This will enable our demolition contractor to take the buildings and walkways down safely.

We will be leaving a single vehicle access point into the car-park, which will enable the health centre to use their 14 reserved car parking bays.

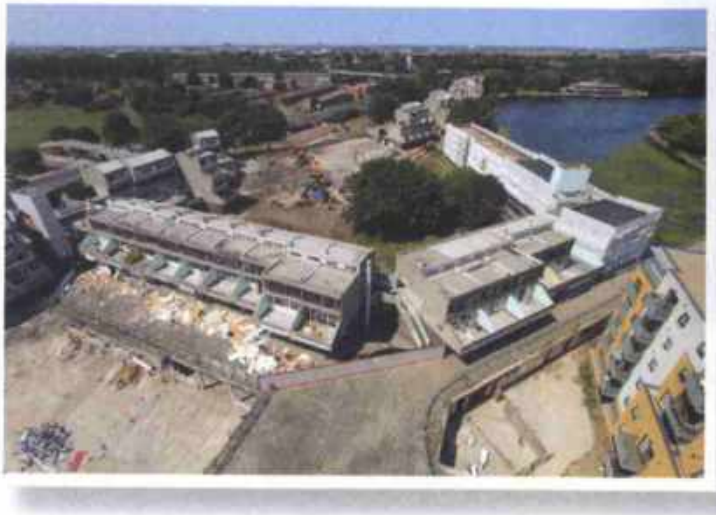
Hoarding:
Upon the completion of the demolition works Kier will erect permanent hoarding. Can you all remain vigilant as changes will take place as from mid July 2013. To increase awareness Kier kindly placed notices in and around the car park to remind everyone of the pending changes. Until further notice can you encourage visitors to use other forms of transport as parking provisions will be reduced as a result.

HOP & SHOP:
Despite a recent advertising campaign take up of the service is low. Please take advantage by obtaining further information from Bexley Accessible Transport team on 01322 311333.

As usual, thank you all for your support and understanding. If you have any concerns please do not hesitate to contact either:

Jan Gill, Regeneration Delivery Manager, on 0300 123 1237
e: Southmere.info@gallionsha.co.uk OR
Scott Moreton Site Manager for Kier Construction on 07791 719073.







WILLING VOLUNTEERS AND TEAM GALLIONS HELP BRING GARDEN TO LIFE

LAST YEAR THE ROYAL BANK OF CANADA DONATED THEIR AWARD-WINNING CHELSEA FLOWER SHOW GARDEN TO US. THE ORIGINAL IDEA BEHIND THE BLUE WATER GARDEN, WAS TO EXPLORE THE CONCEPT OF RAINWATER MANAGEMENT AND BIODIVERSITY.

We were successful in getting the garden because of the fact that Thamesmead is built on a flood plain where water management is a very important issue. Also, because the Royal Bank of Canada wanted the garden to be enjoyed by people with diverse social and economic needs.

Getting the garden was the easy part; the hard part was battling with the weather to get it set up. It took a group of willing volunteers, (led by our staff), several months of hard work to get it all finished. Volunteers included our own staff, residents and individuals from Community Payback Project.

Steve Pyke, Gallions' Green Spaces Manager, who led on the installation, was very pleased with the finished result and had this to say: "The garden looks brilliant. After months of battling with the weather, I'm really pleased that it all paid off in the end. I just want to thank everyone involved for the effort they all put in".

THE GARDEN IS LOCATED IN TEESWATER COURT.

TENANTS VIEW: NEWS AND VIEWS FROM GALLIONS RESIDENTS

WHAT TO EXPECT FROM AXIS CONTRACTORS By Michael Pavis



WHAT SHOULD YOU EXPECT WHEN YOU HAVE AN AXIS EMPLOYEE WORKING IN YOUR HOME?

Quite simply, they should act as if they are entering their mum's house- with the same respect. Axis operates a 'my mum's house' policy, which means:

- workers must show their identity card before entering your property
- workers must wear plastic over shoe protectors - ask them to put them on as it is protocol that they wear them
- they must clear away any rubbish after the job
- they must have all relevant tools with them e.g. foot stool to reach up high
- they must be polite and helpful



Car parking issue:

RESIDENTS REMIND EVERYONE TO PLEASE PARK IN THEIR DESIGNATED SPOTS

A small reminder to not park your car (temporarily or longer) in a parking space that is not your own. Please find the closest off street parking available. Action can be taken against individuals who park in a space without the correct parking permit so please be mindful of others and respect the correct laws.



DISCOVERY CHILDREN'S CENTRE

DISCOVERY CHILDREN'S CENTRE IS FAST BECOMING THE HUB OF THE LOCAL THAMESMEAD WEST COMMUNITY AND THEY ARE VERY KEEN TO SPREAD THE WORD.

They have a very good outreach strategy to encourage more people to make full use of the facilities on offer. These include:

- male only play group sessions
- stay and play sessions for all
- a nursery scheme for children aged 2-5 years
- advice surgery covering financial help and family support outreach workers to help vulnerable families
- adult learning sessions

The list is near endless and as you become a regular at the children centre you can rest assured that you will be greeted with a smile and made to feel very welcome.

The knowledge of the staff is great and above all you have a brilliant opportunity to spend time with people just like you.

The centre is located on Battery Road Thamesmead West, London, SE28 0JN

For more information contact the centre on 0208 855 2470

INFORMATION FOR LEASEHOLDERS AND FREEHOLDERS

THIS SECTION IS DEDICATED TO INFORMATION RELATING SPECIFICALLY TO HOMEOWNERS



JOIN THE HOMEOWNERS CONSULTATION PANEL (HCP)

WHAT IS THE HOMEOWNERS CONSULATION PANEL?

The HCP's job is to consult and comment on the provision of Gallions' services affecting homeowners, including: service charge issues, repairs, caretaking and environmental issues; To ensure that the homeowner service is efficient and value for money. The Homeowners Consultation Panel (HCP) meet quarterly and on an adhoc basis when required.

There are currently six vacancies available for freeholders, shared owners and leaseholders. If you require any further information or are interested in getting involved.

Please contact:
Samantha Harding,
Resident Engagement and Consultation Coordinator
0208 396 4199 or email
sharding@gallionsha.co.uk

The Homeowners Consultation Panel has asked us to include articles in Thamesview that are relevant to homeowners. As a result we are creating a dedicated question and answer section to help cover this.

Please forward any questions that you would like raised to:
Samantha Harding,
Resident Engagement and Consultation Coordinator 0208 396 4199 or sharding@gallionsha.co.uk



HOMEOWNERS' Q&AS

QUESTION

THERE IS A SERVICE CHARGE COST CALLED 'HEALTH AND SAFETY.' CAN YOU TELL ME WHAT THIS IS FOR?

ANSWER

It covers many items including some statutory inspections relating to health and safety, such as:

- Annual testing and certification of fixed ladders, safety lines and handrails on roofs.
- Water quality testing on water storage systems that may be installed to ensure that it is suitable for drinking; also to make sure we do not have a Legionella outbreak.
- Annual testing and inspection of lightning conductors on our buildings.

Added within these budgets are general mechanical and electrical maintenance tasks such as servicing of boost water systems, roof extract fans, water mains stop valves and water storage tanks.

RESIDENTS HELP GALLIONS PROVIDE BETTER SERVICES

AN UPDATE ON RESIDENT GROUPS FROM HELEN CHAMBERS, GALLIONS RESIDENTS GROUP & EQUALITY OFFICER

Gallions' Residents Group (GRG), our resident scrutiny panel, monitors and scrutinises Gallions' performance across a range of services.

The group recently looked at Gallions communication with homeowners around service and estate charges. They look at a wide range of information including: examples of letters to homeowners, invoices and reconciliation statements. The Group also met with managers and a solicitor who specialises in leasehold law, looking at feedback from homeowners including the Homeowners Consultation Panel.

Gallions Residents Group made some recommendations which have been agreed by Gallions including:

- Consult with homeowners to provide a comprehensive guide for them about service charges – this should be both on the website and in paper form.
- Change the way that complaints are recorded so that 'informal' complaints are captured.
- Review service charge communications with homeowners.

Resident Auditors – our team of Resident Auditors have now completed the third and final stage of their training with Housing Quality Network (HQN). The training allowed them to gain skills in auditing and learn how to make quality recommendations.

They have recently looked at the following services:

Aids and Adaptations – one of the recommendations from this audit was to provide training on disability and mental health awareness for staff. This has now been arranged. A copy of their report is available, please contact Helen Chambers for a copy: **t: 020 8308 4098**
e: hchambers@gallionsha.co.uk

Complaints – As a result of this audit the complaints policy will be revised with residents and a method of capturing anonymous complaints will be developed.

If you would like more information on what is planned as a result of the GRG scrutiny and Resident Audits please contact: Helen Chambers on 0208 308 4098 or email her at hchambers@gallionsha.co.uk

GRG scrutiny panel members

Deborah Frimpong
George Ameyaw
Marlene Hunter
Joanne Bernard
Con Lobo
Katie Fish
Kande Ahmed
Fade Olorunlambe
Wendy Walker
Cherry Kent
Michael Pavis

Resident Auditors

Nigel Barnes
Janice Butterworth
Carol Downes
Patricia Quinoo

A huge 'thank you' to all GRG members and Resident Auditors for their time, effort and commitment in helping us to improve services for all residents.

NEIGHBOURHOODS DAY
BRINGS THE COMMUNITY TOGETHER

Residents from the Moorings in Thamesmead (SE28) had a day of fun, advice and learning about job opportunities at Gallions Housing Associations' first neighbourhoods day event on Tuesday 16 July from 1pm-5pm.

Our partners, including Trust Thamesmead gave advice on managing finances and job searching tips. Contractors, Axis, P&R and SCCI Alphatrack gave tips on home improvement and shared information on their apprenticeship programmes. The progamme encourages people out of work back into the workforce by teaching and training opportunities in the trades industry.

Chris Francis, Head of Asset Management at Gallions said: 'This was a brilliant example of the community coming together, teaching each other new skills and knowledge sharing. It also allows us and our partners to offer advice and tips like home improvement, which can save residents a lot of money"

Other activities included, pot planting put on by our staff and Friends of Thamesmead Parks, free dog tagging and responsible dog-ownership handy tips. Local children were entertained throughout the day by games and activities put on by us and our partners.

Don Tidey, committee member for 'Friends of Thamesmead Parks added: " It was great to meet residents and see some familiar faces. We enjoyed teaching local Thamesmead residents how to garden and enjoyed having the youngsters involved too!"





Congratulations to Mrs Anderson who won the gift basket at the event!



GALLIONS AND PEABODY RESIDENT ROAD SHOWS – **A SUCCESS!**

RECENTLY GALLIONS AND PEABODY HOSTED THREE ROAD SHOWS ACROSS THAMESMEAD. RESIDENTS HAD THE OPPORTUNITY TO ASK BOTH ORGANISATIONS QUESTIONS ABOUT THE FUTURE AND WHAT THE PARTNERSHIP AGREEMENT WOULD MEAN FOR THEM.

One of the residents that met Peabody staff at the road show was Thamesmead's first inhabitant, Terry Gooch. He was at the last of three events carried out in Thamesmead over the past few weeks to gather residents' views on plans for the two organisations to join forces later this year.

On what was a very sunny Tuesday afternoon (4th June) along Coralline Walk, Mr Howlett, Peabody's Chief Executive, couldn't hide his delight. He said: "It was great to meet so many Gallions residents at the road show, and really interesting to hear their views on our proposals for the area. What struck me most of all was people's passion for Thamesmead. Together, Gallions and Peabody have ambitious long-term plans which we hope will transform the area over the coming years. I'm really excited about working with the local community for the benefit of Thamesmead."

Previous events were held on 18th and 21st May. Around 500 residents attended all three; with an overwhelming majority supporting the intentions of Peabody and Gallions to come together. This was pleasing news for current Gallions Chief Executive, Tony Cotter. He said: "I'm encouraged by the feedback we are receiving from our residents on the prospect of Gallions and Peabody working together. I know this will accelerate the regeneration, making life better for people who live in Thamesmead."

The next step will be for the Homes and Communities Agency (the industry regulator) to consider the proposal for the two organisations joining towards the latter part of this year.

HOW ARE WE PERFORMING?

APRIL - MAY 2013

Complaints - We received 19 complaints in this period. We monitor them and try to learn from our mistakes	Targets	Actual	
Complaints responded to within timescale	90%	96.34%	
% of residents satisfied with the complaints process	75%	94.44%	
Contacting us			
Calls answered within 20 seconds	80%	93.87%	
Repairs			
Appointments kept as % of appointments made	99%	100%	
% of repairs completed right first time	93%	90.61%	
Average numbers of days to re-let a home	24 Days	35 Days	
Rent			
Rent collected as % of rent owed	99.5%	95.79%	
Team Gallions			
Abandoned & untaxed cars reported to us		8	
Abandoned & untaxed cars reported to Local Authority		8	
Amount of normal waste removed	140 Tonnes	116.71 Tonnes	

 Performance is at or above target

 Performance is slightly below target

 Performance is significantly below target

How to complain or give a compliment

There are lots of ways for you to comment on the services:-

By telephone: 0208 308 4080
Through the website: www.gallionsha.co.uk
Email: Complaints@gallionsha.co.uk
In writing: to PO Box 268 DA15 0FB

GALLIONS AND TRUST THAMESMEAD **WIN POCKET PARK BID**

Gallions Housing Association in partnership with Trust Thamesmead and the London Borough of Bexley have been awarded £35,000 from the Mayor of London, Boris Johnson, as part of his 'pocket park' initiative to help create 'The Link Pocket Park'.

Located next to The Link, Thamesmead's brand new £6.2m youth and community hub, 'The Link Pocket Park' will feature new and improved community spaces - including an outdoor social space for cultural events, an outdoor gym and improved lighting and artwork on the only pedestrian connection between North and South Thamesmead.

The Mayor of London, Boris Johnson, who is funding 100 'Pocket Parks' across London said: "London is already an incredible place to live, but by making the most of our small forgotten outdoor spaces and providing trees, greenery and meeting places the fantastic quality of life here can still be improved upon. Through these mini transformations we can make our communities even better places to live in, to work in and to invest in."

As well as transforming a poor quality 'left-over' space, dominated by large-scale roads and utilities, the proposal will provide both a focal point for positive outdoor activities and transform walking and cycling: it will also enhance jobs and training opportunities. The park will liven up an underused space by creating attractive places that can be used flexibly for a range of community activities.

Dan Hill, Head of Regeneration at Gallions, said: "The Link is a fantastic facility. This partnership investment will do a lot to make it easier to access The Link and easier to walk and cycle in this part of Thamesmead. It will also create some fantastic social spaces for use by all parts of the community".

Richard Fishlock, Head of Social Enterprise at Trust Thamesmead, agrees: "For years we've all been keen to improve the journey across the Eastern Way Bridge, and being able to tie that in with the provision of some unique and engaging enhancements to the green spaces surrounding The Link is a brilliant opportunity".

THE PROJECT WILL SEE THE FOLLOWING SPACES FORMED:

- A sports micro-site, featuring table tennis and an outdoor gym;
- An outdoor performance space;
- A quiet sculpture and planting garden;
- Upgrade of the Eastern Way Bridge with striking lighting and artwork;
- The newly revamped areas will involve residents in all aspects of development, with overall completion planned for Autumn 2013.

Keep an eye out for communications on how to get involved.



Interview with:
Malcolm Taylor
Pest Control Technician for Gallions

MALCOLM SAT DOWN WITH THAMESVIEW EDITOR, AISHA VANCE AND EXPLAINED WHAT HIS DAY TO DAY JOB ENTAILS

'Responsibility for pest control at Gallions, is much more cost-effective for residents than to have it done by a company' explains Malcolm Taylor, who has been at Gallions for 5 years. 'Our end goal is to get rid of the problem, whereas exterminators make a profit if the problem persists.'

When I asked Malcolm what Gallions' main concern is with pests he stated that if our properties are affected by pests, and if left untreated they can cause huge amounts of destruction to the properties.

Malcolm has seen a lot of homes destroyed by pests and suggests quick intervention as the best solution. 'If you notice mice, cockroaches or any other insect/ vermin in your property don't delay in reporting it— let us know as soon as possible so we can intervene quickly with the least amount of damage possible.'

If you suspect you may have a pest problem call Gallions on 0300 123 1238 and report it immediately.

The number of pest control jobs by type of pest that Gallions has undertaken in the past year....

Type of pest	Number of jobs
Ants	1
Birds	173
Bugs	33
Cockroaches	96
Dead animal removal	4
Fleas	5
Flies	20
Foxes	7
Mice	242
Pharaoh ants	7
Rats	44
Squirrels	7
Wasps	21
Total	660

HOW TO BE **FIRE SAFE!**

THAMESVIEW EDITOR, AISHA VANCE GETS THE INSIDE SCOOP ON HOW TO PREVENT A FIRE FROM THE LONDON FIRE BRIGADE, WATCH MANAGER, JOHN HOWLING, WHO HAS WORKED AT THE BRIGADE FOR 27 YEARS.

CAN YOU TELL ME A LITTLE ABOUT WHAT YOU DO?

My role is a watch manager at the London Fire Brigade and my job involves managing the day to day work and watch at Plumstead fire station.

A typical day at the fire station will include training the firefighters, ensuring that our fire engines and equipment are ready for calls, giving fire safety advice to the public, fitting smoke alarms to people's homes and carrying out inspections to gather information on buildings in our area. Then of course, there are the wide variety of incidents we get called to.

WHAT MAIN PIECE OF ADVICE WOULD YOU GIVE TO OUR RESIDENTS ABOUT FIRE SAFETY AWARENESS?

Be fire aware. There are a number of ways that a fire can start and the effects can be devastating. How you live and the way you use equipment can significantly reduce the risk of a fire starting. There's no better way of dealing with a fire than preventing it from starting in the first place.

WHAT ADVICE WOULD YOU GIVE TO OUR RESIDENTS ABOUT WHAT TO DO IF A FIRE BREAKS OUT IN THE BLOCK WHERE THEY LIVE?

- If you live in a flat or maisonette within a block and there is a fire somewhere in the building, you're usually safer staying in your flat unless heat or smoke is affecting you. Purpose built flats and maisonettes are designed to give you some protection from fire. Walls, floors and doors will hold back flames and smoke for a time.

- Call 999 from any phone. Give them the address including the number of your flat, and tell them which floor the fire is on.

- If there is a fire in your flat, leave the building closing the door to your flat behind you if a fire starts, the priority is to get everyone out and call 999. Don't try to fight a fire yourself.

- If you live in a building with a lift, do not use it if there is a fire, go down the stairs instead.

- Make a fire escape plan. Preparing and practising a plan of action will help you to act quickly if there is a fire. Everyone who lives, or is staying in your home should know this plan, and it helps to go through it with your family or anyone else that lives or stays with you.



TELL US ABOUT THE IMPORTANCE OF SMOKE ALARMS

A working smoke alarm is essential. It provides vital early warning and extra time to escape if there is a fire. Every home should have at least one working smoke alarm.

If you need a smoke alarm you can buy one for around £5 - £10 from most supermarkets, DIY stores and electrical equipment shops. We provide free smoke alarms to older people especially those living alone and to those with mobility, vision and hearing impairment, mental health services users and those liable to intoxication through alcohol/drug use.

If you already have a smoke alarm you should test it each week using the test button and every six months, gently vacuum it to remove dust. You should also change the battery every year (unless it is a ten year alarm) or if the low battery warning sounds (an intermittent bleep). It is also best to replace smoke alarms with completely new ones after 10 years.

WHAT ARE YOUR TOP FIVE TIPS FOR AVOIDING FIRES FROM STARTING IN THE HOME?

1) If you are a smoker, never smoke in bed or when you are sleepy, take extra care if you have been drinking alcohol or taking medication, use a proper ashtray and don't empty it into a bin.

2) Turn off the hob if you have to leave the kitchen whilst cooking and never fill a pan more than a third full with fat or oil.

3) Switch off and unplug electrical equipment when you are not using it – only leave on appliances that are designed to be left on, like the fridge or your DVD recorder.

4) Check for signs of loose wiring and faulty plugs or sockets (such as scorch marks or flickering lights) and have any problems you find fixed by an electrician.

5) If you use candles , make sure they are in a proper holder and are not too close to anything that could catch fire. Double check that they are out and never leave one burning when you go out or go to sleep.

WHAT'S THE MOST DISTRESSING THING YOU HAVE ENCOUNTERED AT A FIRE AND WHAT CAN OUR CUSTOMERS LEARN FROM THAT?

I have been involved in tragic fires where people have died because they did not know what to do when fire broke out and could not escape in time. That's why making an emergency fire plan is so important.

FOR FURTHER ADVICE AND TO REQUEST A FREE HOME FIRE SAFETY VISIT YOU CAN CALL IN AT YOUR LOCAL FIRE STATION OR VISIT OUR WEB SITE: WWW.LONDON-FIRE.GOV.UK





Interview with:
Billy Devereux
Senior Environmental Operative

Profile on a Team Gallions employee

What is your role at Gallions?

I am a Senior Environmental Operative, looking after a team of 5 people, I am responsible for looking after Crossways, Moorings, Waterfield, Manor Way and Broadwaters side of Thamesmead

How long have you been working at Gallions?

I have been with Gallions for 17 years

Can you give us a glimpse into an average day?

I start by dropping the guys in my team off in the areas that they are responsible for. I then go round clearing any bulk rubbish, making sure any defects or faults are reported to Axis. I also take care of any larger rubbish collecting that residents phone up about and clear all fly tipping.

What is your favourite part of the job?

Working out in the open, communicating with the residents and making sure every thing is ok.

Can you tell me something about yourself?

I have lived in Thamesmead since I was a kid, I still live here and I'm lucky enough to work where I live.



BOREDOM BUSTERS...
THINGS TO DO THIS HOLIDAY

- SUMMER 2013 -

BAMM!

SUMMER IS ON ITS WAY AND ONCE AGAIN WE ARE PUTTING TOGETHER A BRILLIANT PROGRAMME OF ACTIVITIES THROUGHOUT THE SCHOOL HOLIDAYS.

WITH NEW ACTIVITIES BEING ADDED EACH WEEK THERE WILL BE SOMETHING FOR EVERYONE. SO COME ON, WHAT ARE YOU WAITING FOR?

YOU CAN BOOK NOW!

SOFTBALL CRICKET COACHING
FIVE DAY COURSE FOR JUST £39.00
FOR 8-12 YEAR OLDS
19-23 AUGUST
10AM - 3PM

NETBALL COACHING
FOUR DAY COURSE FOR JUST £32.00
FOR 8-12 YEAR OLDS
27-30 AUGUST
10AM-3PM

LOG ON, OR GIVE US A BUZZ TO FIND OUT MORE
SPORTINGCLUBTHAMESMEAD.CO.UK
020 8320 4499

TRUST. THAMESMEAD

DATES FOR YOUR DIARY

5B KIDS WEEK!

1-31 August

Treat your children to a live theatre experiences thanks to the great offers available during kids week. For more information, check out www.visitlondon.com

OPEN HOUSE LONDON!

21-22 September

Celebrate London's architectural wonders as Open House London throws open the doors to hundreds of buildings in and around the capital 21-22 September. For more information, check out www.openhouselondon.org.uk

CANARY WHARF JAZZ FESTIVAL

Friday 16th to Sunday 18th August 2013

www.londontown.com/LondonEvents/Canary-Wharf-Jazz-Festival/541d7/

LOLIBOP FESTIVAL

Friday 16th to Sunday 18th August 2013

www.londontown.com/LondonEvents/LolliBop-Festival/9d10c/

DANCE CLASSES START SEPTEMBER 2ND!

Tot classes are £2 and Tots £3.50
New Tots classes start 2nd Sept at Thamesmead School of Dance. Byron Close SE28 8AA

Mon 4.30 to 5.15 Disney pop
Mon 5.15 to 6.00 Musical theatre
Tue 4.15 to 5.00 Ballet/Tap
Sat 9.45 to 10.30 ballet/tap

WIN WITH OUR WORD SEARCH

IN THIS WORDSEARCH WE HAVE HIDDEN THE NAMES OF SIX DIFFERENT CARS. FIND THEM ALL AND YOU COULD WIN A £30 SHOPPING VOUCHER.

Mustang
Civic
Explorer
Lamborghini
Caravan
Bentley

W	A	E	B	F	C	G	D	H	E	I	F	E
E	A	H	G	I	M	J	N	K	O	L	C	M
X	N	B	E	N	T	L	E	Y	R	K	I	M
P	Y	U	E	V	A	X	B	Y	C	Z	V	A
L	B	A	C	R	D	I	E	V	F	T	I	R
O	T	E	I	B	L	J	S	K	R	L	C	M
R	N	C	A	R	A	V	A	N	R	Z	S	A
E	C	U	W	V	E	X	O	Y	M	Z	Q	Z
R	Y	R	X	Y	V	D	U	R	T	O	S	E
R	K	Q	N	P	S	O	H	N	O	M	R	L
Q	L	A	M	B	O	R	G	H	I	N	I	X
E	Y	D	Z	C	A	B	B	A	C	Z	D	Y
E	X	W	T	V	M	U	S	T	A	N	G	R

DID YOU KNOW...

The first self-propelled car was invented by Nicolas Cugnot in 1769. It was designed with three wheels and an engine in the front along with the boiler. The car was able to run at a speed of 6 km/hr.

Please return your completed wordsearch and details to: Communications Team, Gallions Housing Association, Freepost RSLT-LYEG-HZAL, PO Box 268, Sidcup, DA15 0FB or drop it into our reception by Monday 2nd September 2013. The winner will be selected at random.

Name:

Address:

Telephone:

Email:

CONGRATULATIONS... to Pauline Cooper who was the winner of our last wordsearch competition.

kidsview WORDSEARCH

IN THIS WORDSEARCH WE HAVE HIDDEN THE NAMES OF SIX DISNEY FILMS. IF YOU ARE LUCKY ENOUGH TO FIND ALL SIX YOU COULD WIN A DVD PACK.

SNOW WHITE
CINDERELLA
PINOCCHIO
FINDING NEMO
PETER PAN
TOY STORY

S	N	O	W	W	H	I	T	E	V	P	J	C
J	H	L	U	E	I	T	V	M	J	O	I	I
B	N	O	M	C	L	P	K	D	J	Q	H	N
I	I	G	V	F	J	E	X	C	K	A	Z	D
P	U	L	P	E	T	E	R	P	A	N	F	E
I	J	H	X	I	K	J	Y	K	L	O	U	R
N	F	Q	O	E	P	R	O	F	R	S	S	E
O	K	U	Y	V	L	X	Z	Y	M	Z	M	L
C	S	R	C	F	D	S	R	G	F	T	G	L
C	L	I	Z	E	A	E	B	P	A	N	Z	A
H	P	S	T	G	O	T	T	H	L	U	X	S
I	M	A	A	T	O	Y	S	T	O	R	Y	D
O	C	F	I	N	D	I	N	G	N	E	M	O

This competition is just for kids under 12. Please return your completed wordsearch and details to: Communications Team, Gallions Housing Association, Freepost RSLT-LYEG-HZAL, PO Box 268, Sidcup, DA15 0FB or drop it into our reception by Monday 2nd September 2013. The winner will be selected at random.

Child's name:

Parent's name:

Address:

Telephone:

WELL DONE ...
to Abbie Warr who was the winner of our last wordsearch competition.